RARE-AI

Individual Project report

For the department of

Computer Science and Engineering (Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning)

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CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that the project titled **RARE – AI** submitted by Paryej Alam **(University Registration No. 304202400900809 of 2024 - 2025),** student of the University of Engineering and Management, Kolkata, in partial fulfillment of requirement for the degree of Bachelor of Technology in Computer Science and Engineering (Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning), is a bonafide work carried out by them under the supervision and guidance of Prof. Shuvendu Das during 4th Semester of academic session of 2025 - 2026. The content of this report has not been submitted to any other university or institute. I am glad to inform that the work is entirely original and its performance is found to be quite satisfactory.

Signature of Supervisor
Department of CSE (AI & ML)/ Department of CSE (AI)

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ABSTRACT:

Rare diseases represent a low percentage of the world's total population but are complicated by an absence of large-scale medical information, late diagnosis, poor public awareness, and a high degree of complexity within their symptoms. Therefore, the earlier rare disease can be identified, the better will be the health outcome for patients. However, many healthcare systems do not have the capabilities of automated analytical systems designed to analyze rare disease indicators quickly and effectively. To address this problem, RARE-AI, an artificial intelligence (AI) driven machine learning system, is proposed and developed to assist in the preliminary screening and prediction of rare diseases through the use of patient symptoms and medical attributes.

RARE-AI utilized a structured pipeline that included data collection, data preprocessing, feature development, model development, and real-time prediction using a user-friendly interface. Data was collected from multiple medical datasets obtained from Kaggle, Orpha data, and other publicly available healthcare datasets. These datasets were cleaned and transformed into a uniform format using the Extract Transform Load (ETL) technique via kettle. The symptom text data were converted into a uniform format, encoded using a multi-hot encoding method, and added to the patient's medical attribute data to develop a comprehensive training dataset. A Decision Tree model, a Random Forest model, and an XGBoost model will be developed and tested using standard performance metrics, including accuracy, precision, recall, and F1-score. Of these three models, the XGBoost model exhibited the highest level of performance when classifying medical data due to the optimized gradient boosting framework of XGBoost.

The trained model will be used to develop a web-based application utilizing Streamlit to allow users to input symptoms, age, gender, and medical history and receive predictions of the most likely rare disease category along with associated confidence scores. This approach emphasized efficiency, accessibility, and scalability, allowing for preliminary screening for rare diseases to facilitate informed medical decision-making.

Through the automation of preliminary screening for rare diseases, RARE-AI provides assistance to healthcare professionals and contributes to the reduction of time to diagnose rare diseases, providing a basis for further integration with clinical support systems

Keywords:

Rare Disease Prediction, Machine Learning, XGBoost, Medical Diagnosis, Symptom Analysis, Streamlit, Data Preprocessing, Healthcare AI, Early Diagnosis System.

CHAPTER – 1: INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background

A very difficult task in the modern healthcare is diagnosing unusual diseases in patients' cases. By definition, rare diseases only affect a minority of people. This means that the doctor has little experience in diagnosing or treating such diseases. Since the symptoms often are difficult and variable and there is very little information available, it is difficult to realize the existence of such diseases. This leads to incorrect diagnoses, or such made too late. This means that the patient not only loses their quality of life, but also, they suffer longer, need to pay more for his medical care, and do not have the remedies.

According to the World Health Organization (WHO), it is estimated that more than 10 per cent of the population of the world suffers from more than 7000 hitherto recognized rare diseases. Rare diseases are a very distinct burden upon the health of people all over the world, because a large percentage of individuals are affected.

The entry of artificial intelligence programs into the health field has already shown that they are a great power, and it seems as though it is the opening of a large within large realm of the nature of rare disease diagnosis and detection. The high-powered artificial intelligence programs such as the ML (machine learning) and DL (deep learning) become capable of analyzing tremendous amounts of data from new sources, at a rate unthought of before, and with accuracy that was not obtained in the past. The programs are able to gather and evaluate many and various types of data relative to the patient. Whether in regard to records, or in regard to genetic material, in the taking of the x-ray, or studying the history of each individual patient, the model is able to elicit from the data such information as previously hid relationships, which might show the possibility of the existence of disease of a rare type.

It is readily seen how the early symptoms shown by these two entities will give the physician the opportunity to make an improved diagnosis, the result of which is speed in the obtaining of the much-desired care. This in turn will show greatly increased figures in the death rate and thus reaching the goal of decreased incidence of sickness and death.

1.2 Project Summary

In view of the problems in this area we have planned the project RARE-AI: Machine Learning for Early Detection of Rare Diseases and Difficult to Diagnose Diseases from Basic Patient Details. The aim of RARE-AI is to provide an intelligent automatic screening system, which commercially would be marketed as a component in other health care systems. This would have the advantage of being able to analyse available patient data such as age, sex, occupation, with symptoms, medical history and routine blood tests, but would not require expensive equipment, advanced imaging or genetic tests in order to work. This is necessary in order that early detection of rare diseases can take place cheaply and on a wide basis, as a result they could be diagnosed in small clinics, rural health care centers and in places where resources are sparse.

The RARE-AI system works by training machine learning models and extensive investigation into validated rare disease data sets for example Orpha data so that hidden links could be found between the symptoms and the disease patterns which could not have been detected by the clinician applying the old-fashioned methods of investigation. The system will process the simple data available for the patient and predict a probability of the occurrence of a rare disease and hence produce a risk statement or an early warning of such diseases and that the high-risk cases could then be further investigated if necessary.

The system will be user friendly and will have an interface which allows any trained personnel, both health care and non-health care professionals, to input medical data in an efficient manner.

1.3 Main Functions of RARE-AI

RARE-AI will perform the following functions:

- Input basic patient details
- Process and analyse data using Machine Learning algorithms
- Detect hidden relationships between symptoms and diseases
- Predict the probability of rare diseases
- Output results for medical assistance in decision-making

RARE-AI is intended as a pre-clinical diagnostic decision support tool, and not to replace doctors. It is intended to assist health care personnel, decrease the time in diagnosis and also to identify, as soon as possible, patients with rare diseases that are “High Risk”. The purpose of this is to supply a more rapid method of using the tool for disease screening and identifying patterns for pathological diseases so that suitable patients can be identified earlier for acceptable medical tests and medical assessments. This has the benefit of improved success and less uncertainty in results.

1.4 Benefits from Practical Point

- Advice on the Investigation of Rare Diseases: Identifies pattern of symptoms that are slight, to indicate recognition of various diseases which is more readily obtained.
- Enforcement of the High-Risk patients: Gives assistance to Clinical people in identifying resource allocation to themselves based on those patients with higher probabilities of being rare diseases.
- Decrease in Wrong Diagnosis: Limit the unnecessary treatment of various diseases that could take place and limit costs of medical treatment for all.
- Learning capacity and Scalability: The Model becomes better utilized, for using more data obtained in the training.
- Accessibility: It requires no operability of apparatus which is available for use in resources in poor situations.
- Quality and Support: Gives information obtained from data as to success but continuously lies on the empirical judgment of Experts.
- Ease of Use: A more user-friendly direction and support training assistance to those clinicians of various stages in their experience in this tool.

CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE SURVEY

2.1 Overview of the Surveys in Rare Diseases

Rare diseases have originality compared with common chronicle disease such as the delay diagnosis, few data for patients and complex symptoms. Some quantitative survey type studies have been carried out to give enlightenment concerning these various factors. A remarkable IRB approved study at indiana university investigated the behaviors, practices and experiences among the patients with rare diseases and their fellows with common chronic diseases [1]. The advantage obtained from these surveys give information which can be used to develop the design and implementation of the AI system in various systems such as RARE-AI to increase the early detection of the rare disease in assisting clinical diagnosis.

The study by wang et al. Investigated the use and non-use of technology, identification of information seeking behavior and the attitude towards health clinical staff about this group of people. Information has been gathered which is valuable for selecting features and indelicate information on early identification of rare diseases, preparation for machine learning in rare.

2.2 The Construction and Dissemination of the Survey.

The original questionnaire in the research, which was done by Wang, et al. [1] had been derived from previous literature and altered from others of the Pew Internet and American Life Project and was composed of thirty-five questions divide into four sections.

These were:

- Use of technology,
- Information seeking aptitude.
- Interaction with other health care professionals,
- Overall evaluation of Quality of Care.

In order that the survey might include some testing and revisions for clearness and usefulness, a pretesting of the survey was done in order to get an idea of the number and conditions of difficulty of answering it and some idea of the length of time necessary to answer the survey it was in the distribution of the research made as follows:

- 26 Support Groups for Patients having Chronic Diseases on Facebook.
- 8 Sub Reddit's on Chronic Illness Communities.

A total of 341 responses were secured, and 328 of the total complete responses were analyzed.

As in keeping with the purpose of the RARE-AI project, the kind of survey as well as the subject matter was taken into consideration, laying stress particularly on that which seemed to have the most emergency about early detection, such as symptom reporting, and health care utilization and patient practices.

2.3 Demography of Responses to the Survey.

From the responses to the surveys were gained the following Information.

- Ages: 18 to 71 (M= 31.71, S.D. 12.71). These ages were binned into bins of five years.
- Sex distribution: 30.00 Male, 69.05 Female, 1.45 not specified.
- Countries represented: 22 countries with a large percentage from the United States of America 58.46%, Canada 12.46%, Great Britain 10.39%, and Australia 8.01%.

There were names of diseases used by the respondents in reference to their ailment. These were binned into the following named diseases:

- Rare diseases: 30.34% of the total.
- Common chronic diseases: 60.66%.
- Including both common and rarer diseases, the rarer diseases are classified according to the nomenclature of the position of the National Institute of Health (NIH) Genetic and Rare Diseases Information Center.

2.4 Use and analysis of the survey.

This survey contained several questions of the peculiarity "Check all that apply" which were changed into binary variables giving the total number of 70 variables; these contained information of.

- Patient practices and use of technology.
- Symptomatic experiences and reporting patterns
- Healthcare engagement and interaction.

The following were key findings from the survey of patients with rare and common diseases:

- Differences in healthcare engagement across rare and common disease populations.
- Challenges in acquiring reliable information by patients with rare diseases.
- Variability in symptomatic experiences and diagnostic journeys.

These findings indicate the requirement for data driven solutions that may enable analysis of various data sets of patients, in order to determine subtle symptomatic patterns occurring, which is the sole aim of the RARE-AI project.

2.5 Relevance to RARE-AI

The findings from the survey were directly used to inform the RARE-AI project in these ways:

- Highlighting the importance of detecting subtle symptoms, which may suggest rare diseases,
- Guiding the identification of features of patients used for the training of ML models, including patient age, gender, symptomatology and past medical history,
- Identification of the requirement for prioritization tools to aid clinicians in early risk element assessment,
- Demonstration of the utility of AI and ML systems in reducing delays in diagnostics and reducing misdiagnoses.

By using the data from the survey along with clinical and patient data, RARE-AI provides a practical and scalable method for the early identification of rare and hard-to-diagnose diseases with the concomitant improvement of healthcare accessibilities and improved patient outcomes.

CHAPTER 3: PROBLEM STATEMENT

3.1 General Problem

One of the major challenges across modern healthcare is the early detection of rare and hard-to-diagnose diseases. By their very definition, rare diseases affect small numbers of the population, meaning that clinicians have little experience in diagnosing and treating them. Symptoms are often complex, variable, and often overlapping with more common diseases, making early diagnosis extremely difficult. Patients routinely receive multiple misdiagnoses, delayed treatment, prolonged suffering, which increases healthcare costs, and decreases personal quality of life

According to the World Health Organization (WHO), there are more than 7000 rare diseases affecting up to 10% of the global population, placing a major burden on healthcare worldwide. Traditional methods of diagnosis will prove insufficient due to:

- The limited availability of specialists charged with the care of people having rare diseases.
- The unavailability of large, well-documented data sets is required for early diagnosis.
- The high expense and unavailability of advanced diagnostic tools such as genetic testing and imaging.
- The slow, laborious work of analyzing the patient's history and symptomatology.

The above problems point out the need for data-oriented, intelligent systems to assist the clinician in the early diagnosis and intervention with the rare disease patient.

3.2 Factors Contributing to the Problem

There are several factors that make the early detection of rare diseases very difficult:

- Limited Clinical Experience: Because of the low incidence of rare diseases, it is safe to say that most of the clinicians engaged in their treatment have had very little experience in their diagnosis.
- Limited Data: Patients are few because of the very rare incidence of the disease, and thus extensive clinical data is lacking. This is both as far as research and demonstrably as far as the application of Machine Learning is concerned.
- Complex and Overlapping Symptoms: These symptoms frequently simulate diseases of frequent occurrence, causing confusion and delayed diagnosis.
- Fragmented Responsibility for Health Records: The history of the patients will frequently be very defective or scattered all over various health facilities.
- Financial Stress: The specialized tests, imaging and consultations with the expert are too expensive or entirely unobtainable in rural or resource-limited communities.

3.3 Implications of the Problem

- The difficulties in early detection of rare diseases have other complications:
- High Danger of Misdiagnosis: Patients may be treated for wrong diseases which results in inefficacious therapy.

- Delayed Intervention: Long periods of diagnostic work improve the patient's conditions negatively and reduce the efficacy of the treatment.
- Financial Responsibility: The patient must undergo repeated consultation, undergo unnecessary tests, and prolonged illness, which enhances the costs of health care both from the patient's aspect and the systems.
- Diminished Quality of Life: The extended periods of uncertainty and the ineffectiveness of the treatment, which result from its delay, must have an adverse effect upon the physical, emotional and social status of the patient.

3.4 The Need for Improved Detection

The problems outlined above illustrate the urgent need for intelligent data-driven approaches to assist in the early detection of rare diseases. Systems utilizing machine learning and other forms of artificial intelligence can:

- Detect subtle symptom patterns frequently overlooked by clinicians
- Priorities further investigation of the highest risk patients
- Reduce misdiagnosis and unnecessary intervention
- Provide scalable solutions to health systems which are at resource-deficient points in their development.

It is these different needs which give rise to projects such as RARE-AI, which will assist in amalgamating patient data with intelligent analysis connotations toward improvements in: Early detection, clinical decision-making and improved patient outcomes overall.

CHAPTER 4: THE PROPOSED SOLUTION

4.1 Overview of the type of Solution

To solve the difficulties inherent in early detection of rare and difficult-to-diagnose diseases, the RARE-AI project came up with an intelligent, automated system that uses machine learning (ML) procedures to utilise basic patient data. Unlike existing diagnostic procedures which rely on the large variety of specialist tests or the degrees of chronicity of available medical materiel, RARE-AI concentrates on indices which are available in regular sources, such as:

- Age and gender
- Symptoms reported by patients
- Medical history and co-morbidities
- The results of regular laboratory examinations

The system is aimed to provide coverage in a wide range of health scenarios from small clinics to health situations where the resources available are limited, and to give predictions of risk early on and to assist in the necessary clinical decision-making at the earliest feasible moment.

4.2 The Architecture and Work of RARE-AI

The RARE AI system operates, on the other hand, from a well-defined work scheme through which predictions become increasingly efficient and correct as follows:

1. Data Input: Patients enter basic patient data through a friendly user interface.
2. Data Processing: The data is processed by the system which cleans and standardises input, the handling of missing or conflicting data items.
3. Feature Discovery: The basic features in respect of symptom combinations, patient history templates, and risk factors are revealed.
4. Machine Learning Analysis: Pre-trained machine learning models now operate. The features enable the subtle relationships between symptoms – disease e.g. to be revealed.
5. Probability Prediction: A probable parameter is calculated for the patient's diagnostics of rare diseases, and patients are classified consequent as to their risk indications (low, medium, high).
6. Input from Decision Support: The anticipated outcome is provided by means of alerts or early indicators of risks to clinicians enabling them the processing of priority indicative cases for investigations, etc., or to specialists considered.

4.3 Main Features or Elements of the proposed interference.

The RARE AI system contained the essential features to enable the solution to the problem of the detection of rare diseases.

- Availability: Operable on only simple or elementary patient material with the consequent disappearance of the need for expensive tests or techniques.
- Early Recognition: The recognition of slight modes of the occurrence of symptoms which have been confused in the different clinical tests.
- Decision supply: The provision of its decision to supply in consonance and in am of such understood lines of the necessary data required sufficient to render its assistance to the clinician at a practical proposition.
- Scalability: These models in machine learning are improved when further and varying patient data have been examined and processed.
- Economies of Resource: There is a decrease of dependence on the rare disease specialist or high technological expensive laboratories.
- Patients Need Orientated: The alert for any risk factors in such patients will be materially contributory to the minimizing the time factors, emotional factors, financial factors and risk factors which lay different upon them.

4.4 Advantages over previous techniques.

It has considerable advantages over ordinary detection of rare disease:

- Time saving: The delays in diagnosis are limited, since the uncounted symptoms of many patients are capable of being considered at the same time.
- Data supply: The new procedure is data based and analyses the curative symptoms through ML for some hidden mode or correlation which would not be available to the physician.
- Efficacious to Important Diagnosis with Early Recognition: The patients who have a serious disease can be "early caught" and cures instituted early.
- Universally Applicability: It may be worked in rural clinics or colleges, or small hospitals where in trivial or no care specialist may be achieved and delays huge in diagnosis.
- Continuous Learning: The Improvement of the system during the years is evident by new continuingly taken data and between different tries as evinced in the time taken to permanent improvement which do not needless involve any capital or otherwise tangible preliminary products but a change of habits in the users for continuous learning.

4.5 Compliance with aims of the project.

The RARE AI proposed modification works fitted in with that of the object as follows:

- Cures misdiagnosis: The terribly mis diagnosis or long time without diagnosis is how much lessened by indelible alerts given for new risk factors.
- Assists specialists: In the same known term of establishment the RARE AI is a decision supply succored or assisted by AI but not substitute or replace specialists.
- Imparts efficiency to medical care: The early detection of rare disease normal is a relation to able logical outcome in low resource organizations.
- Leads to unit improvement of patient care: The important tipping of the balance of referral is much earlier to their receiving the specialist assistance, for consideration and proper treatment, before immediate care. Enabling of the dangerous phase of the disease or levels of illness is altogether a better effect instead of chronic wasting sow to non-attention and the opportunities gone and contempt of the patient which involves later stages of abnormality.

CHAPTER - 5: EXPERIMENTAL SETUP

5.1 Overview

The RARE-AI project focuses on the early detection of rare and hard-to-diagnose diseases using machine learning. Rare diseases can have complex and overlapping symptoms, making it difficult to determine the diagnosis in good times. This chapter gives a complete explanation of all the experimental setups necessary. It includes the hardware and software requirements, sources of data, preprocessing of data, training models, evaluating and deploying the AI model.

5.2 Hardware Requirements

Component	Specification
Processor	Intel Core i7 / Ryzen 7
RAM	16 GB
Storage	512 GB SSD
Monitor	15.6-inch Full HD
Power Supply	65W or above

Adequate hardware ensures smooth execution of data preprocessing, model training, and evaluation.

5.3 Software Requirements

Software / Library	Version / Notes
• Python	3.10+
• Pandas	Latest
• NumPy	Latest
• Scikit-learn	Latest
• XGBoost	Latest
• Joblib	Latest
• Matplotlib	Latest
• Kettle (Pentaho)	Latest
• Kaggle / Orphadata / GitHub	—

5.4 Dataset Overview

Sources: Kaggle, Orphadata, GitHub

Content: Patient symptom records labeled as having a disease (rarity or common)

Location: data/raw/dataset.csv

Key characteristics:

- Features: Symptoms, age, gender, optional test results.
- Label: The name of the disease.
- Format: CSV
- Purpose: To provide examples on which the ML models can learn relationships between symptoms and diseases.

Using validated data sources increases the reproducibility of the experiments and adds useful real-world implications of the validated models.

5.5 Data Integration & Cleaning

Tool: Kettle (Pentaho Data Integration)

Activities:

- Integration of the data sets from Kaggle, Orpha data and GitHub.
- Deleting empty records and duplicate records.
- Standardizing the format of the symptom's column.
- Exporting csv cleaned data into data/processed/dataset_cleaned.csv.

Python Data Cleaning Steps:

- Changing the symptom text to all lower-case letters.
- Deletion of duplicate records.
- Properly filling in cases of not-present records and records correctly.
- The normalization of symptoms.

Clean and consistent data is essential for accurate ML model predictions.

5.6 Feature Engineering

Task	Tool / Method
Symptom Encoding	Multi-hot Encoding
Disease Label Encoding	Label Encoder (scikitlearn)

The Models require numeric data in order to work therefore the need for feature encoding is necessary.

5.7 Train-Test Split

- Tool: Scikit-learn train test split
- Method: 80% training, 20% testing
- Purpose: To see how generalizing will be stratified by the unseen patient data.

5.8 Model Training & Benchmarking

Models Trained:

Model	Purpose
Decision Tree	Baseline model for minimum expected performance
Random Forest	Stable model with reduced overfitting
XGBoost	Optimized for complex medical tabular data

5.9 Model Evaluation

Key Evaluation Metrics:

Metric	Importance in Medical AI
• Accuracy	Overall correct predictions
• Precision	Correctness of predicted disease cases
• Recall	Most critical — captures actual disease cases
• Confusion Matrix	Visualizes misclassifications

Visualization: All visualizations will be generated through Matplotlib, made evidence of the reporting.

In medical AI, recall of priority will be done in order not to make unmissed disease cases.

5.10 Model Saving

Tool: Joblib
File: models/rare_ai_model.pkl
Purpose: Saves the trained ML model for future inference without retraining.

5.11 Inference System

- Input new patient symptoms → ML model → Predicted disease
- Provides a ready-to-use AI solution for rare disease detection

This represents the operational phase of RARE-AI.

5.12 Summary of Experimental Setup

Step	Tool / Method
• Dataset Collection	Kaggle / Orphadata / GitHub
• Data Cleaning	Kettle + Pandas
• Feature Encoding	Multi-hot + LabelEncoder
• Train/Test Split	Scikit-learn
• Model Training	Decision Tree / Random Forest / XGBoost
• Model Evaluation	Scikit-learn + Matplotlib
• Model Saving	Joblib
• Inference System	Python Script

This end-to-end experimental setup ensures reproducibility, reliability, and professional deployment of the RARE-AI project.

CHAPTER – 6: CONCLUSION & FUTURE SCOPE

6.1 Conclusion

The RARE-AI project addresses one of the biggest challenges in modern health care: the early diagnosis of rare and difficult to diagnose diseases. Such diseases occur in only a small fraction of the population, leading to limited exposure of clinicians and a lack of experience in diagnosing and treating these conditions. The difficulty is exacerbated by the fact that the symptoms of rare diseases may be complicated, overlapping, and extremely variable, easily simulating common diseases. The result is a delay in diagnosis, multiple misdiagnoses, escalating diagnostic costs, and lessened quality of life of patients.

The necessity for such modification is obvious because it is here that a quantitative approach is indicated. The difficulty attending diagnosis rests with the sparse rarities and the complicated syndrome of the diseases of this character. The RARE-AI linear object processing system utilizes the machine learning phenomenon and fitted data for such work as secured from standard sources, including Kaggle and Orphadata to be able to point out the more subtle symptom-disease relationship which is so hard to demonstrate through clinical evaluation. The overlapping of data will point out possible satisfactions. In the light of recognition of the above possibilities, it is planned to introduce freshness of information from the data in a systematic manner.

To be able to accomplish the foregoing, it will be evident that improved facilities for information will be necessary, since a lack of education is one of the greatest difficulties with the clinician. First it will have to be carried out on a sufficiently large scale to cover all cases more or less frequently coming to examination.

Realized in this light, it is possible that future directions will have to include a loading of each disease severity of any based on a system of the medical diagnosis, in which later improved processes can be supplied by tardive inspection of a series through the variable severity of a series of therapy subjects of clinical peculiarities. These analyses can be collected so as to enable those concerned to answer the respective sciences of clinical insanity on data collection.

This feature will be of great importance for reducing delinquency in diagnosis and distressing, which is obtained in rare disease management. By showing up the lives which are at a certain risk, the task of presenting different means through consideration of further treatment can be advocated by the clinic with the need checks which are formerly unnecessary, therefore such means of delaying in treatment can be successfully postponed. The consequences will be treated to have a resultant gain to human health, making for greater finality of intention for any ailment and thus contributing either to give fulfilment to the ultimate end of existence there is a burden to be born of emotional grievances from the disappointment expressed by them in foregoing the causal difficulties, both sentimental and material, to say nothing of the effect to be expected from remedying such necessary acidity of states.

In addition, the project places great emphasis on ethical and responsible AI, including patient privacy, data security, and minimizing bias. The systems ensure the continuity of fairness in the predictions they

supply, transparency in the decision-making processes and compliance with best healthcare practice These factors allow for the development of RARE-AI with the aim of increasing confidence in the systems and their usability in the real-world clinical setting.

The significance of the project goes beyond immediate clinical applicability. The data relevant to rare diseases are often fragmented and poorly exploited with the consequence that both epidemiological studies and much research are difficult to perform. By systematically capturing symptom patterns and disease correlations, RARE-AI provides contributions to a wider knowledge of what manifestations of rare disease will tend to produce. This knowledge is necessary for medical research; the collection of disease registries and public health measures designed to increase knowledge and improve management of rare diseases.

The RARE-AI project then serves to illustrate the appropriateness of the synergy of computational intelligence and medical knowledge in providing workable solutions to this complex and vital healthcare problem. The continuing development of the project will ensure its continued refinement and compliance with clinical demands, thus promising well for this initiative in the field of AI-driven solutions for healthcare.

6.2 Future Scope

The future potential of RARE-AI is vast, reflecting the ongoing nature of the project and the scope for future expansion and improvement. The areas of improvement lie in the main areas surrounding the project and can be outlined as follows:

1. More Improved Data Set Expansion: Ongoing collection of more data sets from hospitals and medical institutions, research databases and verified online search engines will widen the ability of the system to learn from many more cases of rare diseases. A better diversity and increase in the data set should improve the model's ability to recognize rare patterns of disease symptoms, with an aim from continuing minimization of false negatives.
2. Advanced Feature Engineering: The introduction of more patient specific features, such as laboratory test results, imaging results, and genetic typing and previous medical history on a long term basis should improve the prediction capability of the model. This would provide an enhanced insight into disease state changes, and deliver more customized predictive modelling over time.
3. Algorithmic Optimization: The exploration of ensemble models, learn deep learning architectures and hybrid approaches may improve the predictive potential of the system. It may also be designed to benchmark the predictive potential of multiple models automatically for different disease groups providing the most accurate and reliable.
4. Integration with Clinical Workflows: Future development may include lines of continuity with electronic health record systems (EHR) and hospital information systems which provides clinicians with access to predictive information with respect to their operational needs thus ensuring usability and acceptance in clinical practice.

5. Interpretability and explainability: It is important that the predictive potential is made clear for clinicians' acceptance. Visualization, confidence scores, and correlation maps for symptoms will all help them understand the rationale of predictive influences and build trust for possible informed decisions.
6. Patient-Facing Tools: RARE-AI could consequently evolve to include patient-facing modules whereby patients may input symptoms and receive advice about rare potential diseases. This will not be a replacement for recourse to the doctor, but will be a relevant tool to give patients, their families or friends information to ensure a timely recourse to medical advice and empower the understanding of rare disease in general.
7. Ethical AI Practices: Ensuring fairness in working throughout populations and ensuring patient confidentiality and auditing algorithms continuously for bias will be important for future developments. Mechanisms for either transparency and accountability must certainly be developed as the situation matures and is implemented in sociological systems in operation.
8. Continuous Learning: The introduction of adaptable learning frameworks may certainly be involved such that each learning or predictive potential may be updated by new patient data as it emerges, research in novel developments or guidelines in one or other mastery. This ensures the RARE-A I approach retains it updating on continuing prevention of newly find rare diseases which need exploration into understanding for treatment or prevention.
9. Global Health Perspective: Finally, expansion of the project with incorporation of international databases and guidelines will make the RARE-AI obviously of enormous value but applied in other countries eligible health systems. This would obviously make contributions to the spread of international rare disease research and all unnecessary efforts for support in the world at large to be aware of an early approach to diagnosis and prevention.
10. Research and Policy Contributions: The information gained from the system can be applied to epidemiological studies, public health policies, and rare disease registries. The available data in structured and analytic form through RARE-AI has the power to affect policy-making decisions and to improve the understanding of the epidemiological aspects such as the frequency and geographical distribution of rare diseases as well as their effective treatment.
11. Scalability and Collaboration: The project can become larger in scope by working with research organizations, hospitals, and rare disease advocacy groups. These partnerships can improve the quality of the dataset, increase representation of patients, and promote standardization in the use and collection of the rare disease data.

The RARE-AI project as a work in progress can adjust itself flexibly to changing problems and discoveries. As new data, research information, and advances in technology become available, the system can continue to develop itself to maintain its relevance and efficacy and clinical application. By pursuing these avenues, RARE-AI can not only facilitate the detection of rare diseases but can also have an important influence upon medical research and patient care and health care innovation on a global basis.

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2. Web Resources

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3. Software Tools and Libraries

- Python3.8+ - The principal programming language for ML and AI development.https://www.python.org/
- Pandas - For data processing and cleaning.https://pandas.pydata.org/
- NumPy - For mathematical operations and overall processing.https://numpy.org/
- Scikit-learn - For training and evaluating machine learning models.https://scikit-learn.org/
- XGBoost - For advanced machine learning applied to tabular medical data.https://xgboost.readthedocs.io/
- Matplotlib - For data visualization and graphical plotting.https://matplotlib.org/
- Streamlit - For user interface for entering symptoms and showing results.https://streamlit.io/

APPENDIX

A. Software tools and libraries

- Python (3.10+) - Main programming language used for AI and ML experimental design.
- Pandas - Data loading, transformation, and manipulation.
- NumPy - Numerical and mathematical operations.
- Scikit-learn - Model training, evaluation and preprocessing for ML classifiers.
- XGBoost - Extensively evaluated ML classifier for tabular medical data.
- Joblib - Saving and loading of trained ML classifiers.
- Matplotlib - Visualization of model metrics for performance evaluation.
- Kettle (Pentaho Data Integration) - ETL tool for amalgamating and cleaning datasets.
- Streamlit - User-interface for entering patient data and predictions.

B. Datasets used

- Kaggle - Symptomatic and disease datasets used for model training.
- Orphadata - Verified examples of rare diseases as datasets for model training and validation.
- GitHub - Open-source medical datasets used for supplemental testing algorithms.
- Key Feature - Symptoms, age, sex, medical history, optional test parameters.
- File type - CSV

C. Data Preparation and Feature Engineering

- Data Cleaning - elimination of duplicates, management of missing features, conversion of symptoms to universal format.
- Feature Engineering -
- Multi-hot encoding for representation of symptomology.
- Label encoding for descriptive categories of diseases.
- Train-Test split - 80%/20%.

D. Machine Learning Classifier Models

- Decision tree. - Baseline model of performance.
- Random forest - Stable predictions made with less chance of over-fitting.
- XGBoost - Optimized model for complex medical datasets.

Training details - hyper-parameter tuning, k-Fold cross validation and appropriate evaluation metrics (Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1 Score).

Model storage - saved via Joblib

E. Survey Template

- Themes included -
- Technology use (secondary use of information, computer and medical technology).
- Purchase of information (information seeking behavior).
- Interactions with HCPs.
- Perception of Quality of Care.

Example questions -

1. Which symptoms have you experienced recently?
2. Have you been referred to consult the services of relevant specialists?
3. What information do you access with reference to your disease?
4. How satisfied are you with the health service that you have received?

Responses were converted to polymers of binary features for the ML analysis.